Lt Gen. Sundarji did not follow this SOP, for reasons given at the end of this chapter.

Lt Gen. Sinha was transferred to army headquarters as vice chief of the army staff (VCOAS) towards the end of 1982. Being the senior-most lieutenant general in the Indian Army, he was expected to take over as chief of the army staff from General K.V. Krishna Rao upon the latter's retirement in July 1983. However, he was superseded by General A.S. Vaidya (six months junior to him) when the latter was appointed COAS on 31 July 1983. Lt Gen. Sinha sought voluntary retirement, and during the NDA government served as India's ambassador to Nepal, and as governor of Assam and Jammu and Kashmir.

During my meeting with the DGS, R.T. Nagrani (Chapter 8), he had told me that the services of SFF commandos were requisitioned at short notice for Operation Blue Star. To help prepare the commandos for their assignment, he had asked the help of the same civilian employee of SFF who had performed the 'casing' of the Golden Temple complex for the aborted SFF-led heliborne operation. This time, this employee stayed in the temple complex for a couple of days and prepared a detailed sketch of it with special reference to the Akal Takht, noting the most suitable points from where SFF commandos could enter with the least possible casualties. For the Akal Takht, he was asked to show the exact number and placement of gun positions, and the floor plan, including the approach route to Bhindranwale's living quarters. These were handed over to Maj. Gen. Brar by the commanding officer of SFF before Operation Blue Star was launched.

Nagrani also told me that the commanding officer of the SFF unit had specifically advised Maj. Gen. Brar that in view of the heavily armed and guarded approach to the Akal Takht, an attack from the front would not be wise. Therefore, it would be better to blast some portion of the rear of the Akal Takht touching the narrow lane behind the temple complex and create a small hole to let the commandos enter the living quarters of Bhindranwale and other areas of the Akal Takht. It was even possible to grab Bhindranwale and his men alive with the careful use of some stun/flash grenades, which disorient the targeted persons for some time. In addition to a